

Simulated Training

Most of us have played or heard of *The Sims*, a computer game that allows a gamer to create virtual characters that interact amongst themselves to reach a common goal. As if giving credence to its fun factor and its popularity (it remains the largest-selling PC game of all time), companies are gradually looking at simulated approaches to creating training modules, wherein participants enter a virtual world to learn skill-sets with a replica of themselves interacting with other participants to perform a certain task or objective.



A scene from the very popular *The Sims 2*

A recent IBM study found that 56 per cent of customers lacked the skills to combining IT technical understanding with business process acumen. (IBM refers to this as “T”-skills). Based on this data, they have designed a 3D educational game simulator, called Innov8, which bridges the gap between IT engineers and business leaders in an organisation.

Innov8

The Innov8 simulation gives the participant the feeling of playing a game, but also teaches events or processes such as business operations. It has proved to be a very successful method of retraining or developing new skill sets. The game is played with a joystick controller and allows participants to visualise how an end-product will function in the customer’s organisation. While playing the game, participants can literally see how the business processes will function, identify bottlenecks, and explore alternative scenarios before the Service Oriented Architecture (SOA) is deployed.

Naveen Gupta, VP, technical sales and support, Software Group, IBM India, says, “Innov8 is a reflection of the way people learn today—it’s got to be interactive, visual and fun. At the end of the game, players are assessed with a score on how well they did, so it’s competitive as well.”

Innov8 is a prototype right now—IBM expects the final version to be completed by September 2007. IBM plans, when it is ready, to deploy the platform over a wide array of industry sectors. It predicts that Innov8 could be used to train middle- or top-level management on Business Process Management and SOA concepts. It can also be used in Higher Education to assist students develop T-shaped skills, thereby making them better managers.

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Visual role-playing in training helps build skill-sets faster

Since it is a game, Innov8 is extremely interactive. Players must achieve certain tasks before they can get to the next level. Completing each task gives them a better understanding of business processes. In the future, IBM plans to make online versions for gaming environments such as *Second Life*, where trainees can participate simultaneously in one session from all across the world. IBM plans to release Innov8 as a free download, so anyone can start playing.

Networking Magic

Another method large organisations are employing is to network their teams working in various parts of the world for better communication during product development. As a result of this networking, skill-sets across various teams and geographic locations can be honed and shared by all teams across the board.

Jazz (www.jazz.net), a joint project between IBM Rational and IBM Research, is designed to build an “open-commercial community” platform that is scalable and extensible based on project requirements, and helps programmers seamlessly integrate tasks across the software lifecycle. In simple words, Jazz allows programmers to build software more effectively while making the entire process of developing software more fun!

How Jazz Works

Most code written for a project is tagged with an author’s name using Jazz. It’s easy to identify which programmer needs assistance: all code can be viewed in real-time by all the teams involved in the project. Once the author is identified, he can be put through a training module to improve the skill-sets he lacks. The training thus happens in real-time. Jazz also integrates messaging protocols into the platform, thereby enabling easy communication between teams.

Since Jazz is in its early stages right now, access to it is only open to employees of IBM Rational’s customers and partners, and a few select others by invitation. The final release date for the platform is yet to be announced.

In the future, IBM plans to use Jazz internally to regulate its own software development lifecycle. It also plans to take a community approach to building various plugins and enhancements for Jazz, so as to make it universally usable, and not just restricted to customers in the IT sector.